

JET AIRWAYS 1.0'S FLIGHT PATH



NUMBER OF
AIRCRAFT*

123



NUMBER OF
EMPLOYEES*

16,000+

1992

Incorporated as a company

HEADQUARTERS:

Mumbai

FOUNDER:

Naresh Goyal

1993

In May, begins operations as an air taxi operator

1995

Launches operations as a scheduled domestic carrier

2004

Starts international operations—flying from Chennai to Colombo

2007

Acquires Air Sahara for \$340 million

2019

Ceases operations on April 17

NOTE THE AIRLINE REBRANDED 'AIR SAHARA' AS JETLITE IN THE SAME YEAR; *DATA AS OF APRIL 17, 2019; **SOURCE** INDUSTRY, BT RESEARCH

airline partners fly passengers and cargo, which means that we can only be successful when our customers are successful.”

While urging JKC to urgently resolve the long-standing issues in adherence with the Supreme Court’s directives, former Jet Airways employee Hariharan emphasises that the new owners must also address the questions arising from the long delay, redress the uncertainty surrounding the financial trajectory to be taken by the carrier and display concrete evidence of forward movement, as “On the ground, the reality remains relatively unchanged since 2019, when the airline stopped operating.” Former Air India hand Bhargava takes a contrarian view, suggesting that a balance must simultaneously be struck to protect the interests of the airline as well as the employees. “A lot of claims come up because employees and other stakeholders believe that if the airline is going to fly, let me first try to get hold of my share of the money. They must understand that once the airline flies and

THE PAYMENT OF EMPLOYEE DUES IS ANOTHER CHALLENGE FOR JKC AFTER ACQUIRING JET AIRWAYS

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makes a decent profit, then they will be able to get their money back.” But if such financial burdens are put on the airline even before its re-launch, it will never take off, he says.

A former Jet Airways 2.0 employee agrees, noting that over time, the once highly valued brand recognition of Jet Airways may start fading, particularly among flyers in their 20s and early 30s who may not have heard of, or flown with the airline. “Just after the Covid-19 pandemic, there was a huge opportunity that has been squandered.” Meanwhile, despite all the odds, sources close to JKC are optimistic about Jet Airways 2.0 launching with six aircraft in the first year, with the number progressively increasing to over a hundred in the next five years. “They [JKC] are actually looking at having 120-plus aircraft as that was the number that Jet Airways 1.0 had at the time of folding up in April 2019.”

If the airline orchestrates a comeback under the stewardship of the new owners, it will also need to adapt to India’s ever-evolving aviation landscape. The industry, meanwhile, will be watching with interest for the Flying Sun’s fate as it will be an important lesson for everyone. But this time, the frequent flyer would hope that General MacArthur’s words, “I have returned!” uttered after his arrival in the Philippines two years later to liberate the nation from Japanese occupation, come true for Jet as well. **BT**

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